they were fighting with each other. The uncle abused his nephew in front of everyone for helping ‘Rajiv Gandhi’s assassins’. The SIT had thought interrogation of the two face to face would help them figure out where the gold was hidden, but instead, their fight almost turned violent, and the SIT had to handcuff Shanmugham and send him off to a nearby police station. It was about nine at night. Shanmugham wanted to have dinner at the circuit house before being sent to the police station. His handcuffs were removed.

Seetharaman was not in sight as Shanmugham quietly finished his dinner. He got up to wash his hands when, in a sudden surprise move, Shanmugham bolted the door from outside and disappeared in a flash. The two constables guarding him were caught unawares and couldn’t catch him. Shanmugham must have scaled the walls of the circuit house as there was no sign of him inside the premises. The guards raised an alarm, and the constables who were posted on the front of the police station ran around looking for him. The first thing they found was his clothes, dropped on the ground—he had taken them off, probably to hide better at night and escape easily. The police immediately issued an alert and sought the people’s help in tracing the smuggler. Police dogs were brought in, followed by raids on houses belonging to his kin. A joint search by the SIT and the local police continued through the night. But Shanmugham seemed to have vanished into thin air.

Around dawn, Shanmugham was found hanging from a tree in a public park about fifty metres from the circuit house. The SIT and the local police claimed it was a suicide. The news spread like wildfire and the press suspected foul play. Either the accused had died in custody from torture or was killed by those Shanmugham was going to expose. In either case, the blame had gone squarely to the SIT, since the accused was found dead while in ‘custody’. The alleged suicide by a key witness had turned the spotlight of investigation back on the investigators themselves. This was a huge setback for the SIT.[7]

The top brass in the CBI was upset with the development. If they admitted it was an outsider’s job, they were accepting there had been a big security lapse on their part. And if they said it was a suicide, it showed